high degree of training in the use of sophisticated techniques and weapons, stealth and surprise are the essential components of any commando operation.

This plan was, however, ruled out by the army top brass, on the grounds that no damage to the Akal Takht was acceptable. This can be contrasted with the actual damage that was done to the Akal Takht. Rather than let the SFF and para-commandos enter the Akal Takht building by creating a man-sized opening, a type of operation for which they are actually trained, Brar eventually made them sitting ducks in the open courtyard, in full view of Shahbeg Singh, who had planned machine gun positions to defend the Akal Takht.

On 3 June, morning curfew was relaxed in Amritsar for a couple of hours to allow pilgrims to enter the Golden Temple to celebrate the martyrdom day of Guru Arjan Dev. Taking advantage of this relaxation, about 200 Sikh extremists escaped from the Golden Temple. They were seen carrying wads of currency notes, reportedly given to them by Bhindranwale.

Dissent in the war room

Maj. Gen. K.S. Brar called a meeting of civil and military officers on 3 June at 7 p.m. to brief them about Operation Blue Star. Also present at the meeting were some senior Punjab police officers, including SP CID Punjab Pandit Harjit Singh, Deputy Commissioner of Amritsar Rameshinder Singh, DIG BSF (Amritsar) G.S. Pandher, DIG CRPF N.K. Tiwari, and Assistant Director IB (Amritsar) G.S. Aulakh. Brar told them that the Akal Takht complex had been taken over by criminals and the Indian army would retrieve the shrine from them through a surgical operation in no time.

Reacting to this, Pandher said that the persons holed up in the Akal Takht complex were no ordinary criminals but about one hundred fully armed and trained Jat Sikhs, for whom there could be no bigger honour than to die protecting the Akal Takht complex. None of them, including Bhindranwale, would surrender. A better alternative would be to cut off water and electricity supply to the complex and starve the inmates for eight to ten days to weaken their